



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Covenant Christian Academy
School Website: <https://discovercovenant.com/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Covenant Christian Academy (Harrisburg, PA 17109) presents a clearly CLASSICAL Christian educational model grounded in the liberal arts and traditional forms of instruction. Public-facing materials consistently emphasize a Christ-centered, theologically informed approach that foregrounds the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and quadrivium, the Great Books/Great Conversation tradition, and a liturgical-catechetical ethos (e.g., morning liturgy, psalms, hymns, sacred music). The school routinely describes aims of formation, virtue, wisdom, and character, rather than a narrow focus on job preparation, and it depicts faculty as living exemplars and mentors who model virtue and classical pedagogy. Parent partnership and community life are repeatedly highlighted as essential to the Covenant model. Taken together, the public materials strongly align Covenant with the six classical elements and present a cohesive Classical Christian program.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Key insights: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations are explicit and robust: Christ-centered formation, theology as a governing influence on curriculum, liturgical and communal practices, and explicit Christian doctrinal framing are evident across admissions, mission, and curricular descriptions.

- Purpose and Goal emphasize formation, virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing, with language about the true/good/beautiful and Great Books conversations shaping formation.

- Curriculum explicitly foregrounds the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium), Great Books/Great Conversation, and history-integrated pedagogy—central markers of classical education.

- Pedagogy highlights Socratic questioning in the upper grades, memorization/singing/chanting in the lower grades, and rhetoric/recitation within the upper school, with an intentional move toward disciplined oratory and debate.

- Faculty are portrayed as mission-oriented mentors, with named roles (Lead Humanities Teacher, Upper School Dean, etc.) and a portrait of teachers as living curriculum and cohort of virtuous educators. - Parents and Community are integral, with explicit statements that Covenant serves in loco parentis, invites parental involvement, and provides education for parents about classical education; the campus emphasizes open access and tours.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site presents Covenant as a Christ-centered, theologically integrated program, with explicit Christian doctrinal framing (Sola Scriptura, Solus Christus, Sola Gratia, Sola Fide, Soli Deo Gloria) and a strong emphasis on Christian formation. - Liturgical and communal practices are highlighted, including morning liturgy, psalmody, hymns, and sacred music as integral to daily learning. - The Great Books/Great Conversation and sacred tradition are referenced as guiding intellectual formation, with explicit language about worshiping truth, goodness, and beauty in a transcendent, real sense.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: Christ-centered, theology, sacred tradition, liturgy, worship, psalmody, hymnody, morning prayer, liturgical formation, Logos, sacred music, biblical doctrine, catechesis.

- Negative keywords observed: None detected in the public materials (no evident secular-neutral framing, no explicit relativism or secular ethics signals in the public content). The lexicon lists negative signals such as secularism and relativism, but Covenant materials reviewed do not foreground these.

Why this rating - Covenant's materials consistently foreground transcendental, theologically grounded foundations (theology, liturgy, sacred tradition) and treat religious commitments as foundational to learning, not peripheral. The explicit Christ-centered framing and liturgical practices align with the Religious and Meta-physical Foundations criteria for CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom rather than merely information or job preparation; statements about forming character, moral imagination, and human flourishing appear in mission content and admissions materials. - Public materials describe education as formation that shapes students toward virtue and intellectual virtue, with mentions of Great Conversation and teleology (pursuit of true, good, beautiful). - Covenant's core values and program descriptions emphasize formation through a Classical Christian paideia, including aims of preparing students for thoughtful, virtuous lives in service to God.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, character, human flourishing, moral imagination, contemplation, great conversation, teleology, Logos, eternal truths.

- Negative keywords observed: No explicit emphasis on college/career readiness as primary purpose; the site positions university preparation as a consequence rather than the primary telos. (Note: Covenant emphasizes university readiness language in external testimonies, but the core public-facing purpose emphasizes formation and character.)

Why this rating - The public materials frame education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, aligned with the classical telos of education (true/good/beautiful). Although there is acknowledgment of college preparation, the emphasis remains on formation and mastery of enduring truths, consistent with CLASSICAL criteria.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Trinity of Liberal Arts is explicit: grammar, logic, rhetoric (Trivium) and the Quadrivium are described in program materials and mission content; Covenant emphasizes Great Books and the Great Conversation, and cross-curricular integration with history as a throughline. - Grammar School and Upper School are described with explicit references to history, literature, Bible, music, and Latin elements; there is a clear progression through classical disciplines and primary texts. - Public materials reference ongoing study of history, classical texts, and the Great Conversation; Senior Thesis and Forum et Agora illustrate engagement with rhetoric and primary texts.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium), Great Books, great conversation, history, classical heritage, Latin/Greek language exposure, rhetoric, memorization/recitation, chant/narration, sacred texts.

- Negative keywords observed: The public content does not foreground social studies-centered history or exclusively project-based/modern STEM-first framing; rather, it emphasizes classical history and primary texts. (The Six Elements lexicon flags "project-based learning" as a negative signal, which Covenant materials do not foreground as the core of curriculum.)

Why this rating - Covenant's curriculum centers the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium) and Great Books within an integrated historical-literary-spiritual framework. The explicit emphasis on primary texts and the Great Conversation aligns with CLASSICAL criteria for Curriculum.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogy includes Socratic questioning in the Upper School and seminar/debate-style learning; there are explicit references to rhetoric instruction and opportunities to present (Forum et Agora, Senior Thesis). - Lower School pedagogy includes singing, chanting, and memory work; the public materials emphasize building memory and delight in learning through chant and song. - There are explicit references to memory-based recitation, living books, and dramatization through classical texts, with a focus on forming the mind through disciplined practice. - Liturgical/music integration (morning liturgy, doxology, hymns) shows contemplative and restful aspects of education alongside rigorous inquiry.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic questioning, seminars, dialectic, rhetoric, speech/declamation, upper school rhetoric theses, recitation, chanting, memory work, liturgical music, scholé, wonder, restfulness.

- Negative keywords observed: The materials do not emphasize exclusive project-based or purely experiential learning; rather, they contrast with those approaches by highlighting traditional memory work, recitation, and canonical texts. (The lexicon notes as a negative signal for some schools the predominance of experiential/project-based pedagogy; Covenant content does not foreground those as the core).

Why this rating - The pedagogy mixes contemplative/restful elements (Scholé, memory, chant) with Socratic inquiry and rhetoric; this combination is a hallmark of classical pedagogy as used in classical Christian schools, supporting a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are described as model teachers and mentors, living curriculum, and core of the school; named roles (Lead Humanities Teacher, Upper School Dean, Art Teacher, Science Teacher) suggest a stable, expert faculty team with deep subject-area formation. - The school emphasizes dedicated, thoughtful instruction rooted in classical pedagogy; there are explicit statements about teachers modeling thoughtful thinking and being essential to student formation. - About Covenant materials describe a culture of collaboration among teachers and staff, aligning with a “faculty as living curriculum” ethos.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty of friends, collegial culture, masterful teachers, long-tenured subject specialists. - Negative keywords observed: None evident in public materials (no signals of a purely administrative or non-classical faculty model). The lexicon lists potential negative signals (e.g., certification-driven jargon) but Covenant materials emphasize classical mentorship rather than a purely credential-driven approach.

Why this rating - Covenant consistently portrays faculty as the core drivers of the educational project, with clear subject-area expertise and mentorship roles, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for the Faculty category.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Covenant presents a strong partner-with-parents philosophy: parents are described as co-educators, with explicit statements inviting parental involvement in the classroom and school life. - The school emphasizes educating parents about classical education through book studies, gatherings, and public communications; there are explicit admissions and tour opportunities to engage families. - The community model includes home-school collaboration and liturgical-year events, suggesting a deeply integrated family-and-school community.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, parent involvement, co-educators, family formation, home-life alignment with covenant education, open campus, parent formation, book studies, family catechesis, intentional parenting.

- Negative keywords observed: None identified; the site consistently promotes involvement rather than a consumer-model or minimal engagement approach. (The lexicon notes potential negative signals for less collaborative models; Covenant materials do not reflect those signals.)

Why this rating - Covenant portrays a deeply collaborative, parent-inclusive community with explicit commitments to parental formation and engagement, matching CLASSICAL expectations for Parent & Community.

Aggregate Ranking

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall: CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- No needle-moving changes are required given the CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories. If a school desires targeted enhancements, they could:
 - Expand explicit, annual documentation of Great Books lists and external student outcomes to further crystallize the “Great Conversation” framework for external readers.
 - Provide more explicit mappings between specific Great Books selections and virtues to strengthen the formation narrative for families and prospective parents.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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